

From Paper to Canvas:

Interpretation of Tennyson's Poems by Pre-Raphaelite Representatives

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The intentional placement of the two artworks, John Everett Millais's *Mariana* (Fig.1.) and William Hunt's *The Lady of Shalott* (Fig. 2.), in Legion of Honor's *Truth and Beauty: The Pre-Raphaelites and the Old Masters* exhibition, arouses my interest for further discovery of the connections between them. First, the poem "The Lady of Shalott," attributed to Lord Alfred Tennyson, the well-known Victorian poet, serves as the literary connection between the two paintings. Second, three visual connections between Millais' and Hunt's paintings draw from their commonalities of textural references.

In addition to their literary and pictorial correspondences, the two paintings also echo each other in the history of the Pre-Raphaelite movement. Millais created *Mariana* from the same-titled poem that opens the Pre-Raphaelite movement in 1851. Over five decades later, in 1905, Hunt published his final version of *The Lady of Shalott*, a painting also inspired by one of Tennyson's poems, at almost the close of the movement. The two Pre-Raphaelites showed great interest in Tennyson's two poems. Millais created *Mariana* in 1851, two decades after the publication of Tennyson's same-titled poem, and ten years later than the second version of the poet's "The Lady of Shalott," published in 1842. As early as 1950, Hunt had started his half centenary study on *The Lady of Shalott*. The simultaneous interests in Tennyson's poem, "The Lady of Shalott," in fact, raise a topic that I will explore in the last part of this paper: the visual responses of the two Pre-Raphaelites to the question from the poem "The Lady of Shalott": whether leaving the tower is a good choice.



Fig.1. (left) John Everett Millais, *Mariana*, 1850–1851, oil on panel, 23 1/2 x 19 1/2 in. (59.7 x 49.5 cm.). The Takins Collection.

Fig.2. (Right) William Homan Hunt, *The Lady of Shalott*, 1886–1905, oil on canvas, 74 x 57 1/2 in. (187.9 x 146 cm.). Wadsworth Atheneum.

From Literary Text to Visual Image

Two poems, “Mariana” and “The Lady of Shalott,” narrate two very similar stories. Both of them have a mentally or physically isolated female as the main character who holds an expectation of love or marriage for a long period of time; both poems end tragically since both women do not unite with their lovers in the end. The poet draws distinct emphasis on descriptions in each work. “Mariana” depicts very few events, but it emphasizes the sense of time, while “The Lady of Shalott” focuses on diverse depictions on events. In this poem, Tennyson combines the method of rephrasing closing lines in “Mariana” and further introduces the action of weaving to further emphasize the passing of time.

Tennyson borrows a marginal character, Mariana, from Shakespeare’s *Measure*

for Measure for his same-named lyrical ballad. In Shakespeare's play, the poor girl Mariana is rejected by her fiancé because her dowry was lost in a shipwreck. The poem continues the story and describes, in seven stanzas, that Mariana is waiting for her lover and finally accepts the truth that her lover will never come. Tennyson uses repeated vocabularies to describe the woman's feelings and her spiritual limitation from waiting.

In the subtitle, the poet further describes the main character's trapped situation:

“Mariana in the Moated Grange”¹

Tennyson puts Mariana into an independent setting with the description of “Moated Grange”, a farm separated with a boundary from its surroundings. The physical isolation hints at her spiritual insulation, which remains a continuous topic in the following lines. To further deliver the woman's progressive, but stagnant, feeling, Tennyson introduces repeated lines at the end of every stanza. For example, at the end of the first stanza, the poet writes:

She only said, ‘My life is dreary.

He cometh not.’ she said;

She said. ‘I am aweary, aweary,

I would that I were dead!’²

Tennyson ends the following five stanzas almost the same way, only changing “my life”

1. Lord Alfred Tennyson, “Mariana by Alfred, Lord Tennyson,” Poetry Foundation, 1832, www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/45365/mariana.

2. Lord Alfred Tennyson, “Mariana by Alfred, Lord Tennyson,” Poetry Foundation, 1832, www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/45365/mariana.

in the first line listed above to “the day” or “the night” to stress the passing of time.³ In the last stanza, “He will not come” replaces “He cometh not” to state the fact that the woman has accepted the truth that her lover has abandoned their relationship. The repeated rephrasing pushes the sense of time elapsing not only from its textural meaning but more importantly from a visual aspect. Tennyson designs each of seven stanzas ends with almost identical patterns that reinforce Mariana’s trapped sensation progressively at repeated lines and until the seventh stanza that she accept accurately deliver Mariana’s frustrated waiting across the boundary of fiction and reality. Each

The sameness of the end of each stanza accurately delivers the frustrated waiting across the boundary of the imaginary literary world to readers in reality. As audiences are reading the same passage over and over again, time has already passed.

Millais is limited in using Tennyson’s literary approach for expressing the passage of time to the medium of canvas. In order to accurately deliver the frustrated feeling of waiting and passing time, the young Pre-Raphaelite pioneer chooses to reference another Tennyson poem, “The Lady of Shalott.” This poem narrates a romantic story with a tragic ending. Lady of Shalott, an imprisoned, mysterious woman living alone, weaves reflections from the mirror in her tower because of an unknown curse that prevents her from looking directly from windows. One day she decides to break the rules of protection

3. Elizabeth Nelson, “Tennyson and the Ladies of Shalott” in *Ladies of Shalott: A Victorian Masterpiece and Its Contexts* (Location: Brown University Dept. of Art, 1985), 6.

and look out as she sees and hears Sir Lancelot from the mirror. The curse falls upon the Lady, and in the end she leaves the tower and finally meets her knight at the moment she dies.

Similar to the poem “Mariana,” “The Lady of Shalott” also contains repeated and rephrased ending lines to stress the passage of time. The refrain, “The Lady of Shalott”⁴ at the end of almost every stanza serves a semblable function as those in the poem “Mariana.” More importantly, the significance of the action of continuous weaving in the poem is demonstrated from three perspectives. First, weaving is a characteristic and representative activity that the lady continuously practices until the moment she decides to break rules and see her knight directly from the forbidden window. In “Mariana,” Tennyson focuses on depicting the characters’ inner feelings and neither weaving nor other needlework has been concluded in the poem to indicate time elapsed. Second, weaving was a part of proper female social behaviors. In nineteenth-century England, weaving, as a time-consuming indoor labor activity, was often associated with female duty. Also, being indoors was widely considered appropriate for a virtuous lady, as it protects her from the sophisticated outdoor environment. Last, but not least, the notion of weaving, similar to the repeated closing lines, serves as the witness of time. It is not hard to see the similarities and connections between the two Victorian poems. The abundant use of refrains appears in both, while the action of weaving appears to further stress the sense of time in this later work of Tennyson’s.

4. Tennyson. “Mariana by Alfred, Lord Tennyson.”.

Millais uses the connections for his interpretation of Tennyson's poem.⁵ In the young painter's painting *Mariana*, he introduces embroidery to achieve a similar visual effect to the one the poet accomplished in the poem.⁶ The precise depiction of her threadwork implies the passing of time while she waits for her lover's news. Reinforced with her gesture of stretching, Millais translates the frustration of waiting from a textural to a visual aspect.

Visual Connections: Millais and Hunt

Weaving in the poem "The Lady of Shalott" builds a web connecting Hunt's same-titled visual illustration and Millais' *Mariana*, as both Pre-Raphaelites reference the same literary text. Among all the similarities, the most obvious one should be the common depiction of threadwork. In Hunt's piece, a giant web of pavonine extends from the foreground to the background in the lower part of the painting. This delicate textile first catches viewers' attention and echoes the significant status of weaving from its literary reference. Hunt narrates a simultaneous moment that the lady is trapped in the web she weaved. Both of her hands are trying to untangle the knit thread around her body. The poetic pose is filled with tension of movements, as if the audience could feel her struggling. In Millais's painting, he borrows the concealed meaning of thread labor to indicate the long wait and Mariana's frustration. The artist depicts a piece of embroidery in front of his character to suggest her long wait. This nearly-finished work is half-opened,

5. Christine Riding, "Brothers in Art," in *John Everett Millais*, by Christine Riding, (Location: Tate, 2006), 14–29.

6. Riding, "Brothers in Art," 23.

with the completed portion rolled at the other end of the table. Tangled, unused threads casually lay on the edge of the textile. Millais masterfully recreates the texture of undulate thread on the embroidery that delivers a realistic effect. Meanwhile, the artist's vivid depiction reminds audiences of the frustrations that they have met or seen in doing threadwork.

Another similarity draws on the introduction of outdoor life-forms entering into indoor space. In *Mariana*, Millais portrays visitors from the outside world in the woman's insular space. From a half-opened window, leaves are randomly sprinkled throughout the interior space, from the unfinished embroidery in the foreground to the wooden floor in the midground. A similar depiction repeats in Hunt's painting, extended from its foreground to its background. Iris petals are scattered in the lower-right corner. They might be blown into this isolated tower by wind, or probably brought by the two white doves flying over petals. Tracing along floating threads up to the background, the second couple of doves are about to escape from the tiny scuttle. The vivid depiction of outdoor life-forms in indoor space emphasizes the isolated situation that both female characters are trapped in. With wings, doves could freely enter and leave this enclosed tower. Even flower petals and fall leaves are able to cross over the boundary of bricks with the help of wind. At this moment, neither of the two women could achieve freedom of movement to the degree that these creatures could. One is imprisoned in her mental confine and the other is limited because of an unknown curse.

These two Pre- Raphaelites simultaneously chose separate depictions of female

and male images in their artworks to indicate the tragic endings in two poems. Millais carries forward a medieval tradition in his artwork to express Mariana's aspirations of love and foretells the crushing of her dream. Similarly, Hunt created an illusion of integration of the Lady of Shalott and her knight in a broken mirror and intentionally separates the couple with a pillar standing between the two.⁷

Millais portrays a metaphoric annunciation within the painting and uses Mariana's gesture to deliver the deepest desire from the character's heart. The major figure, Mariana, is standing in a small velvet dress at the center of the painting, with two hands supporting her waist. Her glance rests on a stained glass window that depicts an annunciation scene with images of Gabriel and Mary standing and facing each other. Her elbow, on the other hand, points to the silver sugar caster placed on the altar. These series of metaphoric depictions require some supported knowledge for full understanding.

Purity, which is also defined as virginity, is often depicted through Mary. To properly protect the Virgin's inviolability, the separation of objects in the annunciation scene (i.e., the mother of Jesus and Gabriel) plays a significant role. The early Renaissance master Fra Angélico often depicts a pillar in the moment of the annunciation to separate the angel and Mary, as well as to signify that God is the father of Jesus, even if he is not present as a visible figure. Gabriel, meanwhile, is often depicted as an elderly figure, which implicitly indicates sexual dysfunction due to advanced age. The purpose of these traditional depictions in the annunciation is to prevent any doubt regarding the

7. Nelson, "Tennyson and the Ladies of Shalott," 8.

Immaculate Conception. Audiences are unambiguously informed, through the technique of visually separating the figures, that Gabriel is not the father of Jesus and that Mary kept her virginity, or purity.⁸

In the painting, Millais captures this ordinary, but stressful, moment that Mariana, tired from doing embroidery, stretches her back and tries to relieve her physical and mental stress. The window frame in the painting that separates Mary and Gabriel symbolizes Mariana's virginity, due to her failed marriage. Mariana's glance falls on Gabriel, who is atypically depicted as a good-looking youth, metaphorically appearing as Mariana's expectation of a future husband. The silver sugar caster in the direction where her elbow points even more forthrightly expresses her sexual desires.⁹

Hunt, on the other hand, portrays an all-around vision of the Lady of Shalott, preparing for the dramatic narration. Audiences observe the lady from her front but are also able to see her back from the mirror behind her. On one hand, this double image depiction delivers a sculptural quality that allows the Lady to achieve one moment of unity with Sir Lancelot; on the other hand, the repeated image allows the artist to provide several clues to indicate the inevitable ending of the two. A significant fissure cuts the mirror in half that implies the arrival of the curse. Her image in the mirror with unrealistic feature, further indicates that the unity of the two should only appear in

8. Erwin Panofsky, "Iconography and Iconology: An Introduction to the Study of Renaissance Art," in *The Art of Art History: A Critical Anthology*, ed. Donald Preziosi (Location: Oxford University Press, 2007), 231.

9. Carol Jacobi, "Sugar, Salt and Curdled Milk: Millais and the Synthetic Subject – Tate Papers,"
www.tate.org.uk/research/publications/tate-papers/18/sugar-salt-and-curdled-milk-millais-and-the-synthetic-subject.

fantasy and reflections, not in her real world. More importantly, Hunt continues the use of the allusive meaning of barriers between couples and places a pillar separating the shadows of the Lady and her knight. By applying multiple subtle implications, the artist euphemistically, but unambiguously, states the future of the two.

Question from the Poem: Is Leaving the Tower a Good Choice?

For the two Pre-Raphaelites, the poem “The Lady of Shalott” reveals an artistic dilemma. Hunt chose to stick with the early Pre-Raphaelite style and belief throughout his career.¹⁰ “Truth to nature” and moral education are the two topics appearing continuously among his artworks.¹¹ Because of these persistent interests, Tennyson’s poem “The Lady of Shalott” appears especially attractive to him, as the poem raises a question: is it best to live in the imagination or to live in reality? Millais, as well, presents his response to this question with an unpublished drawing (Fig.5.). The similarity between the sketch of *The Lady of Shalott* and his famous oil painting, *Ophelia*, presents the artist’s perseverance in pursuing authenticity.

Via fifty-five years of study, Hunt presents his answer to this question through his final version of *The Lady of Shalott*.¹² In the oil painting published in 1905 (Fig. 2), Hunt

10. Isobel Armstrong, “The Pre-Raphaelites and Literature” in *The Cambridge Companion to the Pre-Raphaelites*, by Elizabeth Prettejohn (Location: Cambridge University Press, 2013), 133–147.

11. Christine Riding, “Brothers in Art,” 24.

12. Timothy R. Rodgers, “The Development of William Holman Hunt’s Lady of Shalott,” in *Ladies of Shalott: A Victorian Masterpiece and Its Contexts* (Providence, RI: Brown University Dept. of Art, 1985), 50.

depicts the moment that the Lady is about to leave the tower. This painting depicts not the time she is participating in her signature weaving activity, nor when she is lying in her boat about to die, but the moment she sees and is aware of her destiny. The contradistinctive depictions of tangled threads and the cracked mirror indicate the Lady's dilemmatic situation. Hunt expresses tension between the upcoming death and the current entangling circumstances, as the artist intends to express the recognition "of the terrible fatality which had come upon her, the weirdness of the whole circumstance."¹³

Hunt is the earliest of the Pre-Raphaelites working on this poem and probably also obtains the most numbers of its studies¹⁴. As early as in 1850, Hunt created a highly-finished pencil study of *The Lady of Shalott* (Fig. 4.). The Lady is depicted in a standing pose with threads tangling and floating around her. This initial version appears very similar to the final one, as Hunt unsatisfied with gestures besides standing in many of his later sketches. Only in this pose could the visual illustration deliver the dramatic moment that Hunt desires to present. An early painting of Hunt may illustrate Hunt's response to the question from the poem.

This standing pose of the Lady is connected to the one in *The Awakening Conscious*, another of Hunt's paintings published in 1853 (Fig. 3.). This painting also records a simultaneous moment that a kept woman is about to leave an enclosed space. At

13. Rodgers, "The Development of William Holman Hunt's Lady of Shalott," 51.

14. Rodgers, "The Development of William Holman Hunt's Lady of Shalott," 50-60.

the center of the canvas, Hunt depicts a mistress about to stand up from the lap of her lover. The encircled gesture of the man is similar to the tangling threads around the Lady of Shalott and limits the mistress's freedom. The reflections in the mirror present the mistress's possible future. Hunt even includes tangled threads in the lower right corner to further indicate her stranded situation. The multiple similarities between the two indicate Hunt's interpretation of Tennyson's poem. The tower is no longer the Lady's protection but her durance. Similarly, the apartment of the mistress appears to be a cage. Hunt delivers a homiletic idea to encourage his audiences to break webs that restrict mental freedom and be enlightened with spiritual awakening.

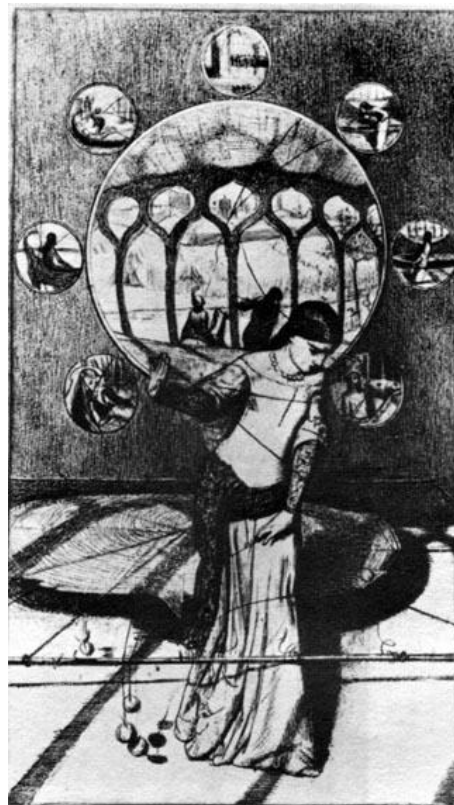
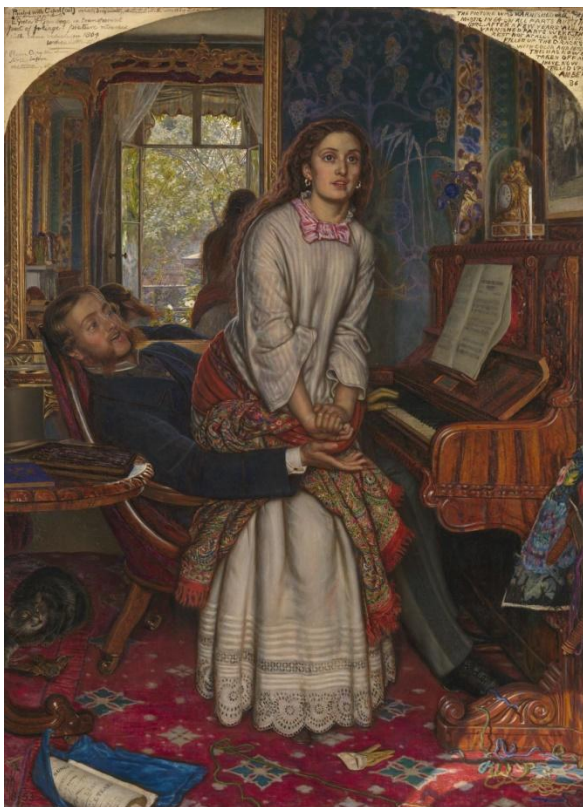


Fig. 3. (left) William Holman Hunt, *The Awakening Conscience*, 1853–1854, oil on canvas, 30 x 22 in. (76.2 x 55.9 cm). Tate Gallery, London.

Fig. 4. (right) William Holman Hunt, *The Lady of Shalott*, 1850, black chalk, pen and ink, 9 1/4 x 5 5/8 in. (23.5 x 14.2 cm.). National Gallery of Victoria, Melbourne,

Australia, Felton Benquest 1921

Little known by the masses, Millais created a sketch of *The Lady of Shalott* in 1854. The drawing depicts the Lady lying in her boat about to die. A swan, which is mentioned in the beginning of the poem, floats next to her head. The similar composition recalls his famous *Ophelia* (Fig. 6), which also portrays a horizontal female figure in water, but the swan in the sketch is replaced with reeds. The important status of *Ophelia* is that it obtains abundant first and second recourses for its signature in realism. Millais presented himself to a real bank at the Hogsmill River, near Ewell in Surrey. The artist himself has complained about the difficulty of painting in an outdoor environment to Mrs. Thomas Combe:

The flies of Surrey are more muscular, and have a still greater propensity for probing human flesh. I am threatened with a notice to appear before a magistrate for trespassing in a field and destroying the hay . . . and am also in danger of being blown by the wind into the water. Certainly the painting of a picture under such circumstances would be greater punishment to a murderer than hanging.¹⁵

Although Millais endured a nightmare process to create *Ophelia*, the artist still depicts his ideal *The Lady of Shalott* with a very similar setting as *Ophelia*. To trace its reason, there might be one hypothesis: by references to his symbolic realism painting, Millais frees

15. John Guille Millais, *The Life and Letters of Sir John Everett Millais* (Location: Publisher, 1899), 119–120.

Lady of Shalott from her tower so she could truly create art close to nature. In the poem, the Lady weaves from the shadows in the mirror. These reflections lack authenticity; they are only the reproduction of the truth, and she could not directly observe nature. As the pioneer of the Pre-Raphaelite movement, Millais could hardly agree with the untruthful environment in which the Lady created her art. Therefore, he chooses to depict her in a similar pose as Ophelia, wishing that the physical death in imagination may return in spiritual life in reality.



Fig. 5. John Everett Millais, Mariana, 1854, pen, brown ink & wash on paper, 24.6 x 16 cm. Art Gallery of South Australia.



Fig.6. John Everett Millais, Ophelia, 1851-1852, oil on canvas, 30 x 44 in. (76.2 x 111.8 cm.). Tate Gallery, London

There are multiple reasons that Millais chose not to publish this sketch. The first one may be the extreme similarities between this drawing and *Ophelia*, an earlier painting he created two years before. The lack of authenticity as well as originality prevents the artist from showing it to the public. Moreover, as Éva Péteri discussed in her journal, Millais's style shifts in the mid-1850s. Romantic themes, such as in *The Lady of Shalott*, contrast with his contemporary portrayal of the melancholic through mostly non-narrative paintings.¹⁶ Nevertheless, this drawing still serves as evidence that records the ideal moment of *The Lady of Shalott* in Millais's heart.

Conclusion

Tennyson's poem, "The Lady of Shalott," inspires Millais and Hunt to do more than just create visual interpretations within the theme; it pushes the two artists to explore broader topics. The multiple pictorial interpretations present Pre-Raphaelites' common interests in this poem, which contains a question closely related to early Pre-Raphaelite practices: is leaving the tower a good choice? Based on these two artists' responses, hopefully this paper will assist readers to create their own answers.

16. Éva Péteri, "Tennyson and His Pre-Raphaelite Critics: Pre-Raphaelite Interpretations of Tennyson's 'The Lady of Shalott'," *School of English and American Studies* (Location: Eötvös Loránd University, 2001), accessed December 10, 2018, http://seas3.elte.hu/anachronist/2001Peteri.htm#_edn41.

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